LIFE OUT OF REACH

Not The Property Of

BOOK CLUB DISCUSSION GUIDE

18 questions for readers and book clubs

BOOK TWO

JAS DOSANJH

Contains spoilers — intended for readers who have finished Not The Property Of.

www.jasdosanjh.com

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

01. What did the title Not The Property Of mean to you by the end of the book? Who believed they had a claim over Jas and her future? And why did they believe that?

02. Jas was taught that a girl should stay quiet and not answer back, yet her silence was repeatedly interpreted as agreement. What does the book suggest about the difference between silence, compliance and genuine consent?

03. Several relatives objected to Jas marrying Jay, yet nobody came directly to ask Jas what she wanted. Why do you think the adults continued talking about her rather than to her?

04. How much responsibility do you place on Jas's parents for what happened and how much on the wider family, community and traditions surrounding them?

05. What did you make of the fact that Jas's parents told concerned relatives that Jas and Jay liked one another? How might the story have changed if someone had asked Jas directly?

06. Jas eventually describes being forced to give up her university place as punishment for dating a Muslim boy and rejecting the marriage chosen for her. How significant was the loss of education compared to the engagement itself?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

07. Jas envies the freedom of her college friends while they envied her for having an attractive fiancé. What does that contrast say about how easily people can misunderstand someone else's life from the outside?

08. Jas describes feeling freer with Azad than she had ever felt before. What was it about that relationship that allowed a different side of her to emerge?

09. How did the Sikh-Muslim divide affect Jas and Azad's relationship? Did the hostility surrounding them make their relationship more significant than an ordinary teenage romance might otherwise have been?

10. What did the contrast between Azad and Jay teach you about Jas's understanding of love, possession and letting somebody go?

11. Jas tells her therapist that she did not choose Jay - she chose her parents and sisters. Did that change your understanding on why she stayed?

12. Were there moments when you wanted Jas simply to leave or run away? If so, did the book alter your understanding of why leaving a family can be far more complicated than physically walking out of a door?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

13. People are often surprised that someone as outspoken and strong as Jas could have been forced into marriage. How does the book challenge the idea that coercion only happens to passive or submissive people?

14. Women frequently help enforce the very rules that restrict other women in the book. Why do you think women can become guardians of patriarchal traditions?

15. Reputation does not belong solely to the individual in Jas's world: her behaviour could supposedly affect her sisters as well. How powerful is that kind of collective responsibility as a means of control?

16. Jas's refusal to take Jay's surname becomes another argument about whether women can truly be equal to men. What did you make of her position on names, marriage and identity?

17. By her wedding day, Jas decides that because Jay is so happy, perhaps she can make herself happy too. What did that moment make you feel about the difference between acceptance and surrender?

18. The wedding presents a public image of celebration while Jas describes having learnt to wear a 'perfect mask'. How important is the gap between appearance and reality throughout the book?

CONTINUE THE CONVERSATION

I'd love to know what your book club discussed.
Email me at author@jasdosanjh.com
Find more about the Life Out of Reach series at www.jasdosanjh.com.